THE HARBOUR CONSORT

Home from Sea

Three new songs and older water music for soprano, cello and harp

SATURDAY 17 OCTOBER 2026 · 6 PM

THE SAIL LOFT, KELLAN HARBOUR



TWILIGHT RECITAL · 17 OCTOBER 2026

Programme

COMPOSER	WORK	DURATION
Felix Mendelssohn	*Venetian Boat Song*, op. 30 no. 6	3′05″
Hester Vane	*The Tide Rises, the Tide Falls* · Longfellow	4′20″
Gabriel Fauré	*Élégie*, op. 24	6′50″
Hester Vane	*Requiem* · Stevenson	3′10″
Claude Debussy	*La cathédrale engloutie*	6′15″
Hester Vane	*Crossing the Bar* · Tennyson	5′40″
	About half an hour, without an interval	29′20″

About the music

Hester Vane wrote *Home from Sea* for the Harbour Consort last winter, and tonight is its first performance. Its three songs set poems written within ten years of one another, and between them the consort plays older water music in its own arrangements, so that each new song follows a piece the room may already know. The poems follow on the next pages, in the order in which they are sung.

Mendelssohn's boat song rocks in six-eight; then, in Longfellow's *The Tide Rises, the Tide Falls*, the harp keeps the tide turning and the cello takes the curlew's call. Fauré wrote his *Élégie* in 1880 as the slow movement of a cello sonata he never finished; its lament leads into Stevenson's *Requiem*, set almost as a folk song.

Debussy's *La cathédrale engloutie*, a piano prelude that Lior Bensaid has arranged for harp, follows the Breton legend of a church that rises from the sea on clear mornings and sinks again. Last comes Tennyson's *Crossing the Bar*, which the poet asked to have placed at the end of every collection of his poems. Vane gives it the same place in her cycle.

The texts

The Tide Rises, the Tide Falls

The tide rises, the tide falls,
The twilight darkens, the curlew calls;
Along the sea-sands damp and brown
The traveller hastens toward the town,
    And the tide rises, the tide falls.

Darkness settles on roofs and walls,
But the sea in the darkness calls and calls;
The little waves, with their soft, white hands,
Efface the footprints in the sands,
    And the tide rises, the tide falls.

The morning breaks; the steeds in their stalls
Stamp and neigh, as the hostler calls;
The day returns, but nevermore
Returns the traveller to the shore,
    And the tide rises, the tide falls.

Requiem

Under the wide and starry sky,
Dig the grave and let me lie.
Glad did I live and gladly die,
    And I laid me down with a will.

This be the verse you grave for me:
Here he lies where he longed to be;
Home is the sailor, home from sea,
    And the hunter home from the hill.

Crossing the Bar

Sunset and evening star,
    And one clear call for me!
And may there be no moaning of the bar,
    When I put out to sea,

But such a tide as moving seems asleep,
    Too full for sound and foam,
When that which drew from out the boundless deep
    Turns again home.

Twilight and evening bell,
    And after that the dark!
And may there be no sadness of farewell,
    When I embark;

For tho' from out our bourne of Time and Place
    The flood may bear me far,
I hope to see my Pilot face to face
    When I have crost the bar.

The performers

The Harbour Consort was formed in 2019 by three musicians who had played together at the town's lifeboat-day concerts for years: Morwenna Hale, soprano, Ada Pryor, cello, and Lior Bensaid, harp. Its twilight recitals in the Sail Loft run from October to March. Hester Vane, the consort's composer this season, writes mostly for voices and small ensembles, and *Home from Sea* is her second song cycle.

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